

We're hearing a lot about how AI may cause human extinction, but will it be because of the artificial intelligence itself, or because AI data centers will drain the world of potable water first?

Posted by u/mypawlak • 0 points • 43 comments

A recent congressional study cites AI as leading to a possible human extinction event. News reports show OpenAI data centers bleeding Arizona and other towns across the country dry of ground water. As AI and its supporting data centers grow, which is likely to have the biggest adverse impact on human survival first?

Comments

u/reincarnateofthepary • 1 points • 2026-02-06 15:06 UTC

Can someone lead me in the direction of articles and sources based on what's been said? Not to prove anything, I just want to read up on it. I'm not falling for the hype, I've tracked fear mongering since COVID and I know the possibility when I sense it.

Thank you!!!

u/devbloke3k • 1 points • 2025-11-18 04:33 UTC

I appreciate you bringing this up, because these conversations matter. Every time a breakthrough technology emerges, there's a predictable cycle: early adopters start building, then a wave of distraction and fear narratives tries to slow the momentum. We saw it with the internet, with smartphones, with cloud computing, and now with AI.

The water-usage argument is one of those narratives. When you look at the data, it's clear the framing is misleading. Almond farming consumes dramatically more water on an annual basis than global data centers, and AI's share of worldwide water intake is roughly two percent. That doesn't mean we ignore the impact, it means we keep the scale in perspective.

What's really happening is a tension between innovation and hesitation. And if history is any indicator, the people who lean into understanding the technology instead of resisting it are the ones who benefit most. AI isn't going away. It's becoming part of the economic infrastructure.

To me, the essential conversation is about responsibility and opportunity. How do we adopt AI thoughtfully, sustainably, and in ways that actually elevate human creativity and productivity? Because the alternative, letting fear-driven narratives dictate our pace, would leave a lot of people behind.

That's why I think discussions like this are important. Not to hand-wave real concerns, but to separate signal from noise and stay focused on what this technology can actually unlock.

u/McKennaJames • 1 points • 2024-03-15 03:11 UTC

Ah yes, good old trustworthy Congressional Studies.

u/FlameSkimmerLT • 1 points • 2024-03-15 02:37 UTC

Neither. It's just another new technology. Electricity, cars, internet didn't kill us. Neither will AI.

Don't believe the hype.

u/my pawlak • 1 points • 2024-03-15 14:09 UTC

The electric chair, road rage and falling into a man hole because you're glued to TikTok. Believe it!

u/FlameSkimmerLT • 1 points • 2024-03-15 14:23 UTC

That's clever. I like your response.

But I think, maybe besides the TikTok one, that's just human nature not the tools. Like, do guns kill people or do people kill people. (Not trying to start a political debate)

u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2024-03-15 16:01 UTC

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u/[deleted] • 1 points • 2024-03-15 00:53 UTC

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u/in20xxdotcom • 1 points • 2024-03-14 22:42 UTC

We are entering a time of water scarcity. We will need to desalinate sea water, add rain catchment systems all over the land, recycle the water from sewer, and maybe go so far as including "gray water" systems to households. I'm ultimately hopeful about or adapting though it will be an investment.

u/supapoopascoopa • 1 points • 2024-03-14 20:29 UTC

Well the idea that humans would intentionally all die of thirst to the level of extinction in order to run helper robots is absurd. So probably not that one.

u/MaybiusStrip • 1 points • 2024-03-14 20:22 UTC

Total yearly US water consumption per year: 278 trillion gallons

Total data center water consumption per year (includes both AI and cloud data centers): 109 billion

Percent of US water used by data centers: 0.0004%

Sources:

<https://www.americanleakdetection.com/blog/2016/march/how-much-water-america-wastes-part-1/#:~:text=Credit%20Loan%20said%20the%20U.S.,using%20all%20that%20water%20for?>

<https://think.ing.com/articles/data-centres-growth-in-water-consumption-needs-more-attention/#:~:text=Water%20consumption%20by%20big%20tech%20firms%20has%20surged,-Some%20data%20centres&text=This%20is%20largely%20driven%20by,water%20consumption%20of%20100%2C000%20homes.>